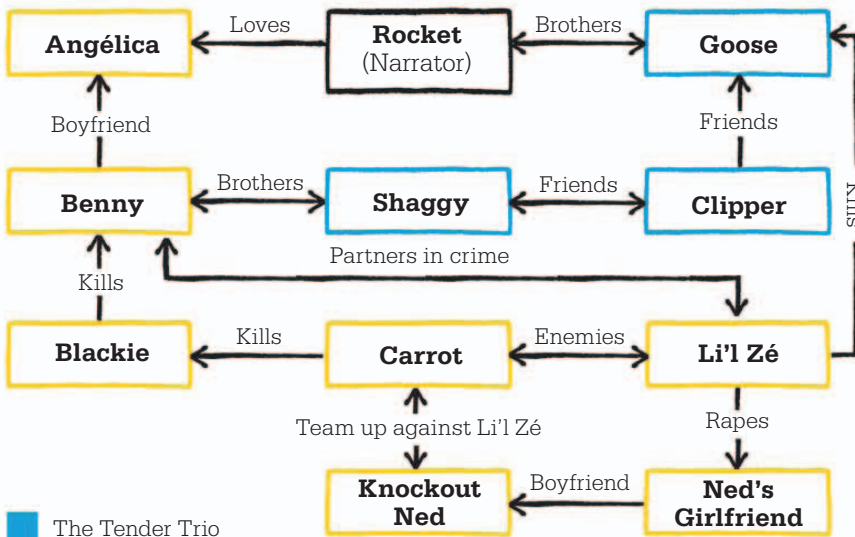


Relationships, allegiances, and enmities



the wicked to thrive and the innocent to perish. This is demonstrated starkly in the movie's opening sequence, in which two chickens are about to be plucked and cooked by Li'l Zé's gang. A knife flashes as it is sharpened against a rock. One chicken flinches as the other is killed, and makes a break for it, but there is no escape.

When Knockout Ned tries to draw a line between being a hoodlum and his noble vigilante mission against Li'l Zé, the City of God intervenes, just as it does when Shaggy tries to flee the criminal life in the name of love, or when Benny decides that he's too good a person to be a gangster. Each time a character gives in to their better nature, that character is punished. They are protagonists in their own Greek tragedies, with the city in the role of Fate.

Journalistic ethics

City of God is a gangster story, an impassioned piece of social commentary, and an ambitious work of visual cinema. Rocket's role as a photographer also allows the movie to touch upon the ethics of journalism in a war zone, or in this case, the act of dramatizing very real problems of poverty and violence. This is highlighted when Rocket confronts a newspaper for

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The sacrificial chicken conveys with the force of a blunt instrument how cheap life has become in the ghetto.

Peter Bradshaw
The Guardian

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into the central character, with other characters entering only when they matter to the overall story of the slum.

The city as fate

One of the main themes Meirelles explores is the favela's corrosive effect on everyone it touches. The violence it spawns does not simply stay among the criminals, but rather is all consuming and perpetuates a culture of suffering for all the inhabitants. Meirelles presents the City of God as an entity in itself, a place that allows

Minute by minute

